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aina Lal Kidwai, former country head of HSBC India, has her hands full. Not

only is the former Ficci president a Senior Adviser to Rothschild & Co India, who sits on the board of a clutch of companies, she also finds time for not-for-profit work in water sanitation, environment and green financing. Kidwai, a chartered accountant by training, was the first Indian woman to do an MBA from Harvard, and one of the first top women executives in the banking space in India. In an interview with *Business Today's* Global Business Editor *Udayan Mukherjee*, Kidwai talks about her not-for-profit work, the role of independent directors, and breaking the glass ceiling. Edited excerpts:

Q: Naina, I remember that time back in 2015 when you put in your papers at HSBC, and everybody said, isn't she quitting too early? You were not even 60 at that point. Do you ever feel that you could have hung on a little longer?

A: So, Udayan, the retirement age was indeed 58. They were extending it by a couple of years but I didn't want to be seen as the one who was hanging on for my benefit, because there were others who were impacted. And they tried to keep me on in advisory roles, etc., but I was quite clear. I wanted to break with banking and move on to do other things, a decision I've never regretted because it's given me the ability to not be a slave to others. You know, when you work in an organisation, you work for their agendas. Some of them can be very uncomfortable. Because there are times when you have to ask people to leave, there are things you have to do that you don't enjoy. What I can do now is to pick and choose what I like—and I have by no means retired from work; I've only retired from HSBC—and my entire portfolio today gives me a very, very full day made up of everything that I enjoy.

It's a mix of being an independent director on a few

boards, global and Indian, but I have committed 40-50 per cent of my time to not-for-profit work in water sanitation, environment and green financing—areas that I'm very passionate about. And I do some advisory work, which keeps me in the flow of what is happening in the world of private equity and investment banking. So, a very full portfolio indeed and not retired at all. And, I would actually urge everyone who is in the moment to think of moving into that next phase.

Q: I can see you have your hands full, Naina, but what do you really enjoy more? Would I be stretching the case if I suggested that you actually enjoy the pro bono work more than the investment banking hat that you still wear?

A: Oh, it's actually both. I do enjoy being in the flow of information and what is happening. It's too many years of experience to just throw out the window, Udayan. It is my core competency, an area where I can still guide and help and mentor and work in. So, I definitely enjoy doing what I used to do. But it does give me time to do some of the things in the broader spaces of water, sanitation, environment, where we are still carving a role for ourselves in the country; [they are] very critical roles. The timing of some of that has been very exciting for me personally because I started the India Sanitation Coalition with my late husband about six months before the Prime

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“I think scrutiny starts very early in our careers as women. You always feel that you are on display. There were people just waiting to see you fall. That puts one under immense pressure”

Minister announced the Swachh Bharat Mission, and it gave us a chance to partner in a very major government programme and work very closely with the government in that programme. That has been a truly rewarding experience.

Having said that, a lot of the work that happens in the NGO world is also fraught with frustration. It's slower than what I'm used to in the corporate